ALMOND-LEMON TEA CAKE

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	TOTAL TIME	OVEN
1 cake, 21.5 cm tube pan or 23 by 12 cm loaf, 8 to 10 servings	**30 min**	**about 2 h 30 min**	**350F for 45-50 min**

INGREDIENTS

95 g	Pastry flour
1/2 tsp	Baking powder
1/8 tsp	Salt
5	Eggs, large
1 tsp	Vanilla extract
200 g	Almond paste, at room temperature
200 g	Granulated sugar
225 g	Unsalted butter, at room temperature
2 tbsp	Poppy seeds
1 tsp	Lemon zest
1 tsp	Orange zest
45 ml	Lemon juice, for the glaze
45 ml	Orange juice, for the glaze
150 g	Confectioners' sugar, for the glaze

METHOD

1. Put a rack low in the oven, in the bottom third, and heat it to 350F. Butter a 21.5 cm tube pan or a 23 by 12 cm loaf pan, dust it with flour and knock the excess out.
2. Sift the flour, baking powder and salt together, then sift them a second time. Set the bowl aside.
3. Whisk the eggs and the vanilla together in a small bowl, just enough to blend them.
4. Fit a stand mixer with the paddle and work the almond paste on low until it comes apart.
5. Pour the granulated sugar in slowly, in a steady stream, beating until it is taken up. Rushing the sugar leaves lumps of paste behind.
6. Cut the butter into 1 tbsp pieces. With the mixer still on low, drop them in one at a time over about a minute.
7. Stop and scrape the bowl down with a rubber spatula. Raise to medium and beat 3 to 4 minutes, until the mixture turns pale and fluffy.
8. Still on medium, pour the egg mixture in very slowly and steadily until it is fully taken up. Stop, scrape the bowl again, then run another 30 seconds on medium.
9. Switch to a wooden spoon and stir in the poppy seeds and both zests.
10. Add the flour mixture in two goes, stirring each one in before the next.
11. Scrape the bowl down a final time, spoon the batter into the pan and level the surface with an offset spatula.
12. Bake 45 to 50 minutes. The top should spring back under a light touch and a tester should come out of the centre clean.
13. Stand the pan on a wire rack and leave the cake in it 5 to 7 minutes, using that window to make the glaze.
14. Stir the lemon juice, orange juice and confectioners' sugar together in a small bowl.
15. Stand the rack over a sheet of waxed paper or foil to catch the drips and invert the cake onto it. Run the tip of a small knife round the edge if the pan will not let go.
16. Brush the glaze over the whole cake while it is still warm, then leave it on the rack until completely cold. Do not try to move it before then, as a warm cake breaks apart.
17. Lift the cold cake onto a serving plate with two icing spatulas crossed under it, or with the removable base of a two-piece tart pan. Serve it at room temperature.

NOTES

The almond paste has to be broken down and smooth before the eggs go anywhere near it. That is what keeps the batter from staying lumpy.
Feed the sugar into the paste slowly. Added too fast it stops the paste breaking up properly.
Mix the glaze immediately before it goes on, and brush it onto a cake still warm from the oven. Both conditions are what let the juice and sugar soak in and crystallise on the surface.
The glaze also seals the crumb, which is part of why the cake stays moist.
Wrapped well, it keeps a week in the refrigerator.